WELCOME TO THE 2026 HACK-AI-THON!

Ask What Matters: Adaptive AI for Smarter Travel Reviews

Kickoff Webinar – April 13, 2026

Wharton
UNIVERSITY of PENNSYLVANIA
AI & Analytics

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HACK-AI-THON

Welcome to the 2026 Hack-AI-thon, presented by Expedia!

ONE REAL BUSINESS PROBLEM
ONE WORKING AI PROTOTYPE
ONE JUDGED EVALUATION

Key Dates

- April 13 — Kickoff, data and full workbook to be emailed immediately after
- April 16 (9:00 AM ET) — Submission Deadline
- April 17 — Finals (In Person)

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What you'll leave with today

By the end of this session you will have:

- A clear understanding of the business challenge
- A clear understanding of what you must submit
- A clear understanding of how submissions are judged
- A concrete plan for how to start building today

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Timeline & Milestones

April 13 (12 PM, virtual)
Kickoff — understand the prompt and define your MVP, start diving into the data
April 14 (4PM, virtual)
Office hours — validate your approach and get help with roadblocks from the WAIAI Data Team and Expedia Data Scientists
April 16 (9 AM via SurveyMonkeyApply)
Submission deadline – Team leader submits your Hack-AI-Thon materials
April 16 (10 AM)
Career Services Event w/ Expedia (more on next slide)
April 16 (5 PM via Instagram)
Finalists announced via Instagram Live @whartonaiai
April 17 (Finalist Teams only, 9AM - 2PM ET in-person)
Final presentations and live demos - details to come for Finalists, entire team should attend

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April 16 Career Services Events w/ Expedia Group

Thursday, April 16th

12:30pm –1:00pm: **Expedia Group Information Session**

- During this session, you'll learn about our mission to bring the world within reach, the values that guide how we work, and the culture that inspires our teams to innovate, create, and connect travelers with life-changing experiences.

1:30pm – 3:00pm: **Coffee Chats with Expedia Group representatives**

- These 15 minute 1:1 sessions are a great opportunity to ask questions about our intern and new graduate programs, learn more about our culture and values, and get tailored guidance on how to stand out in the recruiting process. You're also welcome to bring your resume for quick feedback or to talk through your career interests.

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Prizes

1st Place
$2,000 in Apple products, $400 in OneKeyCash* for each student, recognition on the WAIAI website, and an invitation to present at the Spring WAIAI Advisory Board meeting on Thursday, April 23rd.

2nd Place
$1,500 in Apple products, $200 in OneKeyCash* for each student, recognition on the WAIAI website

3rd Place
$1,000 in Apple products, $100 in OneKeyCash*for each student, recognition on the WAIAI website

*****OneKeyCash*** *is the rewards currency of the One Key™ program for Expedia, Hotels.com, and Vrbo. To receive their award, students must have an active account with Expedia.com, Hotels.com, or Vrbo.com, as OneKeyCash is distributed and redeemed through the One Key rewards program.*

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THANK YOU

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Why Reviews Matter

Reviews influence decisions for future travelers – when looking for places to stay, reviews help:

- Understand what a property is really like
- Compare options
- Build trust before booking

The ease of the review process is also crucial as it shapes both how willing travelers are to leave reviews and whether those reviews are informative and current.

Today, Expedia relies on static review prompts and reactive supplier updates to keep property information fresh, leaving significant data gaps unaddressed.

For Platforms like Expedia:

- Making reviews easy to complete helps everyone
- Better review data improves discovery
- Structured insights improve search and recommendations
- Higher quality information increases booking confidence

User Value of Better Reviews:

- Reduces cognitive load — users don't start from scratch
- Faster — only 1–2 quick, relevant questions
- More submissions — lower effort leads to higher engagement

Business Value:

More and better-targeted reviews fuel recommendations, search, and booking confidence

The Core Problem

Property reviews are rich, but inconsistent. Expedia lacks a systematic way to identify data gaps or areas needing refreshed information about a property.

Common Pain Points:

- Some topics are over-covered; important details are missing
- Information becomes stale — amenities, policies, and renovations change
- Updates come reactively from suppliers, not proactively from reviewers
- Static prompts ask for things Expedia already knows (i.e., “how great the pool is”)

What You're Building

Build a prototype that:

- Identifies missing or outdated property information from review data
- Generates 1–2 personalized, targeted questions per reviewer
- Supports both text and voice input — reducing friction for users
- Enriches Expedia's property knowledge base with fresh, structured insights

Goal:
Capture useful information while minimizing user effort.

The Challenge Dataset

What you receive:

- A structured dataset of publicly-accessible Expedia property review data, curated for this challenge
- A data dictionary explaining fields, formats, and coverage

Recommendation:

- Understand the data *before* you start building.
- The gaps in the data are the problem you're solving.

What Strong Solutions Look Like

Strong solutions demonstrate:

- Intelligent gap detection — knows what's missing, not just what's been said
- Relevant and targeted questions — 1–2 per user, specific to the property and stay
- Low-friction interaction — voice or text, quick to complete
- Clear reasoning — why this question, why now, for this property?

Complexity alone does not win.
A simple system that asks the right question at the right time will outperform a technically impressive one that misses the point.

Submission Requirements & Judging

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What You Must Submit

Your submission must include:

- Prototype link — public working tool
- GitHub Classroom repository
- 3–5 minute demo video (recorded in real time)
- Pitch deck (8–12 slides)
- Optional supporting materials

Submission deadline:
April 16 — 9:00 AM ET

Submission portal:
SurveyMonkey Apply
Note: Your Team Leader (whomever submitted your team's registration) must submit all materials

Demo Video Expectations

3–5 minute real-time demo video.

The challenge here is presenting critical information in a short period of time. Do *not* try to fit too much into your video by fast-forwarding or speeding up your recordings. We will disqualify any recordings that are sped up.

Recommended structure:

1. Problem and context
2. Your AI solution
3. Demo walkthrough
4. Feasibility and scalability
5. Why your project stands out

Pitch Deck Expectations

Length:
8-12 slides, prepare for a 10 minute presentation + 5 minutes for Q&A.

What to cover:
The core problem and why static review questions fail
Your solution and where it fits in the review experience
How AI is used to identify gaps and generate targeted questions
A simple system workflow or architecture
Demo flow and expected user experience
User and business impact
Feasibility, scalability, and key limitations
Why your approach stands out

Tip:
Focus on storytelling

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How You'll Be Judged

Projects are evaluated on six criteria:

1. Innovation and Creativity
2. Technical Implementation
3. User Experience and Design
4. Opportunity and Impact
5. Feasibility and Scalability
6. Presentation

Important note:
Complexity alone does not win.

Tools for Success

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OpenAI API Access

Each team receives:

- One OpenAI API key
- Sent to the Team Leader UPenn email from WAIAI Staff Member Jaden Dicopoulos, jadend@upenn.edu
- The Key is **not** to be:
    - shared publicly.
    - used for anything other than the Hack-AI-thon's purpose.
    - used by anyone who has not signed the DUA.

Practice good security habits and keep your key private! ***Keys that appear in public repositories can be automatically disabled***.

GitHub ClassRoom

All code submissions for the Hack-AI-thon will be done through GitHub Classroom.

Not sure how to submit? No worries! Check the resources folder for a step-by-step guide that will walk you through the entire process.

NOTE:
Make sure to not change the license and do not leak your API Key!

Slack, Mentorship & Support

During the Hack-AI-thon you will have access to:

- Slack workspace for announcements and questions
    - Students will be added immediately after kickoff.
    - Expected response time: within ~6 hours generally, messages received after 9PM will be answered the following day.
- Office hours with WAIAI and Expedia teams: 4:00-6:00 PM ET Tuesday, 4/12

Questions? Contact us via the Slack channel (preferred; quicker response time) or email us at ai-analytics@wharton.upenn.edu (~24 hour response time during business hours)

How to Approach the Hack-AI-thon

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How to Win This Hack-AI-thon

Practical advice for the Hack-AI-Thon:

- Define what “missing” information means
- Define what “stale” information means
- Start with a simple MVP
- Focus on 2–3 strong examples
- Design your demo early
- Explain your reasoning clearly
- Keep the user at the forefront of your design

Guiding Principles

- Never lose track of your objectives
- Prioritize efficiency
- Be mindful of “Pride of Authorship”
- Accept that collaboration is an imperfect science
- Keep the team as flat and egalitarian as possible
- Communication is key

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Common pitfalls:

- Building a generic chatbot
- Creating a tool that asks too many follow-up questions
- Ignoring scalability
- Over-engineering the architecture
- **Submitting at 8:59 AM**

Final Reminders

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A Note from Expedia

We're excited to see what you build!

Our travelers are dependent on trustworthy and current information to make informed decisions on their next adventure. The challenge you're solving is real and the impact will help millions of travelers worldwide.

We hope this challenge gives you hands-on experience with the kind of applied AI problems that matter in the real world.

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Time to Start Building

Next steps:

- Join the Slack workspace, GitHub Classroom, and accept your team's API Key (*Team leader who registered your team)*
- Review the dataset and documentation, and other WAIAI resources in the Box folder linked in SMA and the workbook
- Workbook and other details will be emailed right after the Webinar.
- Define your MVP
- Attend office hours
- Start building today

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GOOD LUCK!